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Trusting Students With Difficult Books: Why School Book Bans Weaken Critical Thinking

Book banning in K-12 schools has become a growing issue in the United States, but not everyone fully understands what that means. When people talk about banning books, they usually mean removing them from school libraries or classrooms because someone believes they are inappropriate. Supporters say certain books contain bad language or difficult themes and that students should not be exposed to these topics. I and many others argue that school is not meant to keep students comfortable all the time. School and the materials in school are meant to help students develop critical thinking. The Virginian-Pilot Editorial Board writes, “ We should want children to face the ideas that are difficult and trust their capacity for critical thinking, a cornerstone of education and, ultimately, democracy” (A Few Loud Voices). I agree with that claim because when schools remove challenging books, they take away chances for students to think through hard topics.

Critical thinking does not really develop when everything feels easy. It develops when students have to pause and figure something out or think through a challenging idea. For example, if a class reads a book about racism or injustice, students might not

all agree on the message. Some may feel uncomfortable, others may feel defensive; But that is where the thinking happens. Students must learn to support their ideas with evidence from text. The Editorial says, “While it’s true that not all material is appropriate for every grade level, these challenging works of literature are vital to a well rounded education” (A Few Loud Voices). Not every book belongs in an elementary school, but removing a book completely is different from placing it into the right grade.

A good example of this is the removal of *Maus*. The Editorial calls it “a haunting depiction of the Holocaust” (A Few loud Voices). The Holocaust is disturbing history. It should be. If students only learn about it through a short paragraph in a text book, they may memorize facts but not truly understand the human cost. Removing challenging topics like war, gender, sexuality, and race from education erases these topics from the minds of students and undoes the lessons we have learned from these topics.

Maus presents the history of World War Two in a way that feels personal. If that book is removed because it makes people uncomfortable, then students lose a deeper understanding of the events. That loss affects how students reason about prejudice, propaganda, and power. It also raises a bigger question: if difficult history is removed because some find it upsetting, where do we draw the line on what is “too difficult”?

Some people say banning books is just about protecting children, and that argument sounds reasonable at first. No one wants children reading something that is clearly too mature for them. However, there is a difference between protecting and restricting, and schools already organize books by age level. The issue becomes more serious when access to a book is removed for everyone. The decision to ban a book affects students whose families may have no issue with their child reading that material.

Research also shows that many recent book bans focus on specific types of books. The Virginian-Pilot Editorial Board describes the removal of *Maus* as part of “a worrisome national trend to limit students’ access to books that have a whiff of controversy” (A Few Loud Voices). Books that deal with slavery, racism, or sexuality are often the only books being banned. If that pattern continues, classrooms will slowly become more limited in what they teach, and students will be left with fewer chances to examine real world issues or events.

The Editorial also warns that this path “Leads to antiseptic classrooms that do not challenge students” (A Few Loud Voices). This will at best, lead to students finding this material outside of classroom settings where teachers can guide students through these challenging topics. Students will still encounter difficult ideas outside of school. They will see this material online, on social media, or in conversations with peers. Without guided exposure to difficult topics in classrooms students will lack the tools needed to properly navigate these same topics in the real world.

Looking at what parents actually believe adds more context to this issue. The *Parent Perceptions of School Libraries Survey* shows that “93% report that they feel their child is safe using the school library” (EveryLibrary Institute & Book Riot). That number suggests that most parents already feel safe with school libraries. The survey also states that “80% of parents report trusting school librarians to select appropriate books for the school library” (EveryLibrary Institute & Book Riot). The level of trust shown in the survey shows that the majority of families do not see librarians as careless when they choose books for students.

At the same time, the survey makes it clear that most parents want involvement in what their child is reading. It reports that 76% of parents think they should be able to decide if their own child can access specific books (EveryLibrary & Book Riot). It is understandable that parents want to guide their children's education. However, guiding your own child's education is not the same as removing books for all students.

When a book is banned, students lose more than just a story. They lose an opportunity to practice reasoning and critical thinking. In a classroom discussion about discrimination in a novel students must argue in defence of, or against a character's actions. Both students must explain their reasoning and use examples from the novel to support their ideas. That process strengthens critical thinking. If the book is removed then those discussions, and the skills developed through those discussions, never happen.

The Editorial connects the issue of book banning directly to democracy when it says critical thinking is "a cornerstone of education and, ultimately, democracy" (A few Loud Voices). Democracies depend on citizens who can evaluate information and handle disagreement. If students grow up being shielded from ideas simply because they are uncomfortable, they may struggle later when faced with those same ideas. Avoiding challenging topics does not prepare students for adulthood.

Protecting children is important, and age appropriate placement of books should always be considered. But completely removing challenging material sends the message that difficult ideas should be avoided instead of understood. Education is meant to develop critical thinking, not limit it. When access to books is restricted because they are uncomfortable, students lose opportunities to examine different

perspectives and think through complex issues.Schools should prepare students for the real world by helping them think critically, not by removing parts that are hard to face.

Works Cited:

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